

CVETANICHIN

THE CLARITY-TO-ACTION OPERATING SYSTEM

*A structured workbook for turning honest reflection
into a results-based 90-day plan*

FOUR STAGES · LIFE AUDIT · ENERGY DIAGNOSIS · VALUES · 90-DAY PLAN

Introduction

Most clarity tools stop at insight. You take a quiz, complete a journal, finish an audit — and you understand yourself better. Then nothing happens, because understanding and action are not the same skill, and almost nothing on the market teaches the bridge between them.

This workbook is built differently. It borrows its structure from results-based project design — the same discipline used to design EU-funded development projects, where a clear problem statement has to become a Theory of Change, has to become a logframe, has to become a monitored, time-bound plan. That discipline works because it refuses to let “we understand the problem” substitute for “we have a plan with indicators we can check.”

You're about to apply that same rigor to your own life.

The Four Stages

- 1. The Life Audit — establish your baseline across seven life domains**
- 2. The Energy Diagnosis — identify your specific burnout pattern and leverage points**
- 3. Values Clarification — rank what you actually want to optimize for**
- 4. The 90-Day Action Plan — convert all of it into a checkable, time-bound plan**

How Long This Takes

Most people complete Stages 1–3 in a single deliberate sitting of 60–90 minutes, then return to Stage 4 once they've let the diagnosis settle for a day or two. There's no prize for rushing this. The plan you build in Stage 4 is only as good as the honesty in Stages 1–3.

What You Need

A quiet hour, this workbook, and a willingness to write the uncomfortable answer instead of the acceptable-sounding one.

How to Use the Branching Paths

Not everyone needs equal depth in every stage. After completing Stage 1, use this guide to decide how much weight to give Stages 2 and 3.

IF your lowest domains were Health & Energy or Career & Work, and your Stage 1 cost-of-inaction answer mentioned exhaustion or depletion:

→ Spend extra time in Stage 2. Your plan will likely center on an energy/burnout intervention.

IF your lowest domains were Purpose & Contribution or Identity & Self-Respect, and your answers kept circling “I don’t know what I want” rather than “I’m too tired”:

→ Spend extra time in Stage 3. Your plan will likely center on a values-realignment or even a career-direction shift. If a full career pivot emerges as your need, treat your 90 days as a first move, not the whole answer.

IF your lowest domains were Autonomy & Control or Relationships & Connection, and your answers centered on other people’s demands on your time:

→ Move through Stages 2 and 3 at a normal pace; your Stage 4 plan will likely center on boundary-setting and structural changes to how your time is controlled.

IF you scored every domain in the 6–8 range with nothing standing out:

→ This system may be premature for you right now. A genuine audit usually surfaces at least one domain that’s clearly lower than the rest. Consider whether Exercise 1.1 was completed fully honestly.

A Note on Honesty

Every worked example in this workbook uses “Maria,” a composite drawn from common patterns, not a real client case. She appears throughout so you have a model of what a fully honest answer looks like — specific, slightly uncomfortable, never vague.

If your own answers feel safer or more polished than hers, that's worth noticing. The exercises only produce a useful plan in proportion to how honestly you complete them.

STAGE 1

The Life Audit

Why This Stage Exists

Most people who feel “stuck” haven't actually mapped where they're stuck. They carry a diffuse sense that something is off, but they've never separated that feeling into its parts: which domain is failing, by how much, and since when.

This stage borrows directly from project audit logic. Before you can design an intervention, you need a baseline. You can't measure progress against a problem you haven't defined.

By the end of this stage, you will have:

- ☐ A scored baseline across seven life domains
- ☐ A ranked list of which domains need attention first
- ☐ A written account of when things shifted, not just that they did

Exercise 1.1 — The Seven-Domain Score

Score each domain from 1 (severely neglected) to 10 (thriving). Don't average — score how it actually feels right now, this month.

Career & Work Score: ___ / 10

What's true right now:

Financial Security Score: ___ / 10

What's true right now:

Health & Energy Score: ___ / 10

What's true right now:

Relationships & Connection Score: ___ / 10

What's true right now:

Purpose & Contribution Score: __ / 10

What's true right now:

Autonomy & Control Over Time Score: __ / 10

What's true right now:

Identity & Self-Respect Score: __ / 10

What's true right now:

Worked Example — Maria, 41, Programme Manager

Career & Work: 4/10 — “I'm good at my job but I've stopped learning. I do this in my sleep now.”

Financial Security: 7/10 — “Stable, not growing. I haven't renegotiated my rate in three years.”

Health & Energy: 3/10 — “I'm tired by 2pm every day. I've stopped exercising since the reorg.”

Relationships & Connection: 6/10 — “Fine with family, but I've lost touch with most friends outside work.”

Purpose & Contribution: 5/10 — “I believe in the mission. I don't feel connected to it day-to-day anymore.”

Autonomy & Control Over Time: 3/10 — “My calendar runs me. I haven't had a free Saturday in months.”

Identity & Self-Respect: 5/10 — “I don't dislike myself. I just don't recognize who I've become at work.”

Exercise 1.2 — The Domain Ranking

List your three lowest-scoring domains. These are not necessarily your three biggest “problems” — they’re the three with the most room to move, which is what you’re optimizing for in Stage 4.

1. Lowest domain: _____ **Score:** ____

2. Second lowest: _____ **Score:** ____

3. Third lowest: _____ **Score:** ____

Reflection prompt: Does this ranking match what you expected before you scored it? If a domain surprised you (higher or lower than expected), write one sentence on why.

Exercise 1.3 — The Timeline of Drift

For each of your three lowest domains, identify the approximate point things shifted. Not the moment you noticed — the moment it actually started changing. These are often different.

Domain 1: _____

Approximate start of decline:

What was happening in your life at that time?

What did you tell yourself about it then?

Domain 2: _____

Approximate start of decline:

What was happening in your life at that time?

What did you tell yourself about it then?

Domain 3: _____

Approximate start of decline:

What was happening in your life at that time?

What did you tell yourself about it then?

Why This Matters

Most decline isn't sudden. It's a slow erosion you adapted to so gradually you stopped registering it as a problem. Naming the start date breaks that normalization.

Exercise 1.4 — The Cost Calculation

For your single lowest-scoring domain, write what staying at this score for another 12 months would actually cost you. Be specific — not “I’d be unhappy,” but what concretely doesn’t happen, who doesn’t get your full presence, what opportunity passes.

If nothing changes in this domain by this time next year:

Worked Example — Maria

“If nothing changes in Autonomy & Control Over Time by next year, I miss another year of my daughter’s actual childhood while telling myself I’ll ‘make it up’ later. I also stay too exhausted to make the career move I keep saying I’m ‘thinking about.’ The thinking never becomes deciding because I never have an unscheduled hour to decide in.”

Stage 1 Summary Box

Lowest domain	
Cost of inaction (one sentence)	

Carry this domain forward to Stage 2.

Stage 1 Checklist

- ☐ Scored all seven domains honestly (not aspirationally)
- ☐ Identified three lowest domains
- ☐ Traced the timeline of drift for each
- ☐ Calculated the real cost of inaction on your lowest domain

STAGE 2

The Energy Diagnosis

Why This Stage Exists

Stage 1 told you where the problem lives. This stage tells you what kind of problem it is — because “I’m burned out” is not one condition. It’s at least four different patterns, each with a different fix. Treating all of them the same way is why most burnout advice fails: rest helps one type and makes another worse.

By the end of this stage, you will have:

- ☐ Identified which of four burnout patterns you're in (or confirmed you're not in one)
- ☐ Mapped your actual weekly energy drains versus energy sources
- ☐ Identified your two highest-leverage energy interventions

Exercise 2.1 — The Four Burnout Patterns

Read all four. Most people are a primary type with traces of a second. Identify your primary.

TYPE A: OVERLOAD BURNOUT

Profile: Too much volume, not too much difficulty. You could do any single task fine — there are just too many of them, with no slack between.

Signature thought: *"If I could just clear the backlog, I'd be fine."*

Common in: People who say yes by default, people in under-staffed teams, people early in a role still proving themselves.

TYPE B: DEPLETION BURNOUT

Profile: The work itself has drained your capacity over time — emotionally, physically, or both. Volume isn't necessarily the issue; the work has a cost per unit that's exceeded your recovery rate.

Signature thought: *"I used to be able to handle this. Now even small things feel heavy."*

Common in: People in care/mission-driven roles, long-tenure professionals, people post-major-life-event.

TYPE C: MISALIGNMENT BURNOUT

Profile: The work is sustainable in volume and not inherently draining, but it no longer connects to anything you value. The exhaustion is existential, not physical.

Signature thought: *"I'm not even that busy. I just don't care anymore."*

Common in: Senior professionals, people who've outgrown a role, people who took a job for security over fit.

TYPE D: AUTONOMY BURNOUT

Profile: The work and pace might be fine, but you have no control over how, when, or whether you do it. The exhaustion comes from powerlessness, not effort.

Signature thought: *"It's not even the work. It's that none of it is my choice."*

Common in: Middle management, people in highly regulated/bureaucratic environments, caregivers.

Your primary type:

Secondary traces (if any):

Worked Example — Maria

"I scored myself as primarily Type D, Autonomy Burnout, with strong Type A traces. The reorg took away most of my discretion over my own calendar and priorities — that's the part that drains me most, more than the volume itself. But the volume genuinely is up too, so I'm carrying both."

Exercise 2.2 — The Weekly Energy Audit

Track this for one real week before completing the analysis below (a tracking template is included as a companion download). If you're completing this without a full week of data, complete it from memory for the most recent typical week — note it's an estimate.

List your five biggest energy drains this week (specific activities, not vague categories):

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

List your five biggest energy sources this week (specific activities, however small):

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

Ratio check: Roughly how many hours went to drains versus sources this week?

Drains: ___ hours Sources: ___ hours

Exercise 2.3 — The Leverage Filter

Not all drains are equal, and not all are fixable. Run each of your five drains through this filter:

For each drain, answer: Can I eliminate it, reduce it, delegate it, or is it fixed (non-negotiable)?

Drain	Eliminate / Reduce / Delegate / Fixed	If not fixed, one action this month
1.		
2.		
3.		
4.		
5.		

Worked Example — Maria

Drain: "Daily 8am status call with no clear purpose" → Reduce → "Propose moving to twice-weekly, see if anyone objects."

Drain: "Answering Slack messages during family dinner" → Eliminate → "Phone in another room 6–8pm, no exceptions, starting this week."

Exercise 2.4 — The Two Highest-Leverage Interventions

From your filtered list, choose the two changes that are both high-impact and genuinely achievable in the next 30 days. Not the most dramatic — the most leveraged.

Intervention 1:

What this requires of me:

What this requires of others (if anything):

Intervention 2:

What this requires of me:

What this requires of others (if anything):

Why Only Two

Burnout recovery plans that list ten changes get abandoned in week one. Two sustained changes outperform ten attempted ones.

Stage 2 Summary Box

Primary burnout type	
Top intervention	

Carry this intervention forward into your Stage 4 plan.

Stage 2 Checklist

- ☐ Identified primary (and secondary) burnout type
- ☐ Completed a real or estimated weekly energy audit
- ☐ Filtered all five drains through Eliminate/Reduce/Delegate/Fixed
- ☐ Selected two highest-leverage interventions for the next 30 days

STAGE 3

Values Clarification

Why This Stage Exists

Stages 1 and 2 diagnosed the problem. Before you can design a plan, you need a filter for deciding what's actually worth optimizing for — because “fix everything” isn't a plan, it's a wish list. Values clarification gives you the criteria your Stage 4 plan will be judged against.

This is not an exercise in discovering some hidden true self. It's a practical ranking exercise: of the things you already know you value, which ones are you actually willing to make trade-offs for right now.

By the end of this stage, you will have:

- ☐ A ranked top-five values list, not just a generated list
- ☐ A clear statement of which values you're currently under-investing in
- ☐ A “non-negotiable” filter to apply to your Stage 4 plan

Exercise 3.1 — The Values Card Sort

Below is a working list of 24 common values. Cross out any that don't genuinely move you (be honest — values you think you should have don't count). From what remains, circle your top eight.

Achievement · Adventure · Autonomy · Balance · Connection · Contribution · Craft/Mastery · Creativity · Curiosity · Financial Security · Health · Honesty · Influence · Justice · Learning · Legacy · Loyalty · Order/Structure · Recognition · Rest · Service · Spirituality/Meaning · Status · Stability

Your top eight (in any order):

1. 2. 3. 4.

5. 6. 7. 8.

Exercise 3.2 — The Forced Ranking

This is the exercise people resist and the one that actually produces clarity. From your eight, you must rank your top five, in order, with no ties.

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

Tie-Breaker Method

For any two values you're stuck choosing between, ask: "If I could only fully honor one of these for the next year, which would I choose?" Whichever answer comes faster (not "more correct," just faster) is usually the truer ranking.

Worked Example — Maria

1. Connection — "Nothing else matters if I'm disconnected from the people I love."
2. Autonomy — "I realize now this is what's actually been missing, not 'balance.'"
3. Contribution — "I need my work to matter, even if I redefine how."
4. Health — "I keep deprioritizing this and it's catching up with me."
5. Craft/Mastery — "I want to be growing, not just maintaining."

Exercise 3.3 — The Investment Gap

For each of your top five values, score how much of your actual time and energy currently goes toward honoring it (1 = almost none, 10 = fully invested). This is not how important it is — you've already established that. This is how much you're actually living it.

Rank	Value	Current Investment (1-10)	Gap
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			

The gap is your highest-priority value with the lowest current investment. This is usually where the most leverage exists — not your lowest score overall, but the biggest mismatch between importance and investment.

Worked Example — Maria

Rank 1, Connection: Importance is highest, current investment is 4/10. Gap: large.

Rank 2, Autonomy: Importance is high, current investment is 3/10. Gap: large.

Result: Maria's two biggest gaps — Connection and Autonomy — match her Stage 1 lowest domains (Relationships and Autonomy/Control) and her Stage 2 burnout type (Autonomy Burnout). The three stages are now pointing at the same thing from three different angles. That convergence is the signal a real pattern exists, not a complaint.

Exercise 3.4 — The Non-Negotiable Filter

Write one sentence defining a non-negotiable boundary tied to your highest-gap value. This sentence becomes a filter you can run any future decision through.

“I will not _____ at the cost of _____.”

Worked Example — Maria

“I will not accept meeting requests during the 6–8pm window at the cost of dinner with my kids.”

Stage 3 Summary Box

Top value	
Biggest investment gap	
Non-negotiable filter sentence	

Carry your top value and non-negotiable filter forward into Stage 4.

Stage 3 Checklist

- ☐ Narrowed 24 values to a genuine (not aspirational) top eight
- ☐ Force-ranked top five with no ties
- ☐ Scored current investment against each top-five value
- ☐ Identified the single biggest importance-investment gap
- ☐ Wrote one non-negotiable filter sentence

STAGE 4

The 90-Day Action Plan

Why This Stage Exists

This is the stage most self-improvement content skips, and it's the entire reason this system exists. An audit without a plan is just an expensive diary entry. This stage converts everything you've surfaced — your lowest domain, your burnout type and interventions, your highest-gap value and non-negotiable filter — into a structured plan with milestones, not vibes.

This stage borrows directly from results-based project design: a clear objective, a small number of outcomes, defined indicators of success, and a realistic timeline with checkpoints.

By the end of this stage, you will have:

- ☐ One clear 90-day objective synthesized from Stages 1–3
- ☐ Three outcome areas with specific, checkable indicators
- ☐ A month-by-month milestone map
- ☐ A built-in mid-point review process

Exercise 4.1 — Synthesizing Your Objective

Before writing your objective, pull forward what you carried from each stage:

From Stage 1 — Lowest domain:

From Stage 2 — Primary burnout type and top intervention:

From Stage 3 — Top value and non-negotiable filter:

Now write a single 90-day objective that addresses all three. This should be one sentence, specific enough that you could explain to someone else exactly what success looks like in 90 days.

90-Day Objective:

Worked Example — Maria

"In 90 days, I will have reclaimed two protected evenings a week for my family by restructuring my calendar boundaries, and I will have had at least one real conversation with my manager about reshaping my role to restore some autonomy."

Exercise 4.2 — The Three Outcome Areas

Break your objective into exactly three outcome areas. More than three diffuses focus; fewer than three usually means you're not being specific enough.

Outcome Area 1:

Outcome Area 2:

Outcome Area 3:

Worked Example — Maria

1. *Protected family time (boundary-setting)*
2. *Restored autonomy at work (one direct conversation + one structural change)*
3. *Sustained energy (the Type D burnout intervention from Stage 2)*

Exercise 4.3 — Indicators of Success

For each outcome area, write 2–3 indicators — concrete, checkable signs that this outcome is being achieved. Avoid vague indicators (“feel better about work”). Use indicators you could honestly mark yes/no against in 90 days.

Outcome Area 1 Indicators:

Outcome Area 2 Indicators:

Outcome Area 3 Indicators:

Worked Example — Maria, Outcome Area 1 Indicators

“I protected at least 6 out of 8 weekday evenings per month (6–8pm) with no work intrusion.”

“I had at least one full weekend day per month with zero work-related thinking, verified by not opening email.”

Exercise 4.4 — The Month-by-Month Milestone Map

Break your 90 days into three monthly blocks. For each month, list the 2–3 concrete actions that move you toward your indicators. Be specific about timing where possible.

MONTH 1 (Days 1–30) — Focus: Establish

MONTH 2 (Days 31–60) — Focus: Reinforce

MONTH 3 (Days 61–90) — Focus: Consolidate

Worked Example — Maria, Month 1

“Have the conversation with my manager about calendar boundaries, by day 10.”

“Set the 6–8pm phone-away rule starting day 1; track adherence weekly.”

"Block two recurring 'no meeting' evenings on my calendar by day 5."

Exercise 4.5 — The Day 45 Checkpoint

Pre-write your own mid-point review questions now, while you have clarity — not in 45 days, when you'll be inside the plan and less objective about it.

At day 45, I will ask myself:

1. Am I hitting my Month 1–2 indicators, or do they need to be adjusted (not abandoned)?
2. What's the single biggest obstacle that's emerged that I didn't anticipate?
3. Does my original 90-day objective still feel right, or has something more important surfaced?

Space for your Day 45 answers (revisit this page at day 45):

Exercise 4.6 — The Day 90 Review

At day 90, score yourself against each indicator from Exercise 4.3 (yes/partial/no), then answer:

What changed that I'm proud of:

What I'd do differently next cycle:

What I'm carrying into the next 90 days:

This Is the Bridge to the Maintenance Phase

Most people's real transformation happens not in their first 90 days, but in their second and third cycle, once the planning muscle itself becomes familiar. Treat day 90 as a checkpoint to re-run Stage 4, not a finish line.

Stage 4 Summary Box

90-Day Objective	
Outcome Area 1	
Outcome Area 2	
Outcome Area 3	
Day 45 checkpoint date	
Day 90 review date	

Stage 4 Checklist

- ☐ Synthesized one clear 90-day objective from Stages 1–3
- ☐ Defined exactly three outcome areas
- ☐ Wrote 2–3 checkable indicators per outcome area
- ☐ Built a month-by-month milestone map
- ☐ Pre-wrote Day 45 checkpoint questions
- ☐ Scheduled the Day 90 review in your calendar now

What Happens After Day 90

You now have a complete cycle: audit, diagnosis, values, plan. The system is designed to be re-run.

Most people's biggest gains come in cycle two and three, not cycle one — because by your second 90-day cycle, the planning itself stops being the hard part, and you can put your full energy into execution and refinement instead of relearning the method.

Before You Close This Workbook

Calendar your Day 45 checkpoint and Day 90 review right now, not later today.

If you have a partner, close friend, or colleague who knows your Stage 4 objective, tell them. External accountability meaningfully increases follow-through.

Keep this workbook somewhere visible. A plan that's filed away gets forgotten by week three.

For Your Second Cycle

The Quarterly Life Review System (available separately) is built as the lighter-weight maintenance tool — you won't need the full four-stage diagnostic every quarter, but you will want a structured check-in. Consider it the natural next step once this first 90-day cycle is complete.

This is not a one-time fix. It's a method. The method is the product.

— CVETANICHIN